

Liberty County Building Department — Training & Intake Guide

Updated September 17, 2026 · For internal staff use only

Purpose

This manual is the primary reference for front desk personnel handling public inquiries, application intake, and fee assessments for Liberty County. It includes guidance on all required forms and the latest state law changes affecting permitting.

I. New construction

Use this section for brand-new residential and commercial buildings, as well as pre-manufactured Accessory Dwelling Units (ADUs).

Permit Coverage

Covers: The structural shell — foundation, framing, exterior walls, and structural roof framing, including the roof covering itself. Roofing is included in this permit; a separate Roofing Permit (Section V) is not required when the roof is installed as part of new construction.

Does not cover: Electrical, plumbing, HVAC/mechanical, and gas work — each requires its own trade permit (Sections II and III).

Intake Rules & Verifications

- **Septic / DEP Check:** Does the property have city sewer? If not, the applicant must provide a Septic Construction Permit or an Existing System Approval from DEP **before** we accept the building application.
- **Notice of Commencement (NOC):** If the total job value is over \$2,500, an NOC must be recorded with the Clerk of Court. You can accept the permit application without it, but inform the customer that the NOC must be filed and posted on the job site **before** they can schedule their first inspection.
- **Setbacks Check:** Verify the plot plan meets minimum building distances from property lines.
 - **Residential (Low Density):** Front 20 ft, Side 20 ft, Rear 20 ft.
 - **Commercial / High-Density:** Front 20 ft, Side 10 ft (20 ft for Commercial), Rear 10 ft (20 ft for Commercial).

FORM REQUIRED: Application for Building Permit

File name: Application_for_Building_Permit.pdf

When to use: Required for every permit type in this guide — new construction, renovations, electrical, roofing, mobile homes, accessory buildings, and miscellaneous work. This is always the first document collected.

What it does: Captures the property owner, contractor, property description, valuation, zoning district, septic/sewer information, and type of work. The Permit #, Fee, and surcharges are assigned by staff upon review.

Note: Under HB 803, the Florida Building Commission must develop a standardized statewide permit application by July 1, 2027. This form is expected to be replaced within the next revision cycle.

FORM REQUIRED: Notice of Commencement

File name: Notice_of_Commencement.pdf

When to use: Required when the total job value exceeds \$2,500 (or \$15,000 for HVAC changeouts). Collect and accept the building application first, but the NOC must be recorded with the Clerk of Court and posted on the job site before the first inspection is scheduled.

What it does: Gives legal notice to lienholders (suppliers, subcontractors) that construction has begun. Required under Chapter 713, Florida Statutes. It identifies the owner, contractor, lender, surety, and expiration date of the notice.

Note: The NOC must be physically posted at the job site. No first inspection will be scheduled until staff confirms it has been recorded and posted.

FORM REQUIRED: Owner-Builder Affidavit

File name: Owner_-_Builder_Affidavit.pdf

When to use: Required any time a property owner is acting as their own general contractor on new construction — including new homes, commercial buildings under \$75,000, and farm outbuildings. The owner must appear in person and sign before the permit is issued. Required under Florida Statute 489.103(7).

What it does: A 12-point disclosure statement in which the owner acknowledges: the legal restrictions of the owner-builder exemption, their personal liability for all work and workers on site, that they cannot hire unlicensed persons to supervise, that they must occupy the property and may not sell or lease it within 1 year of completion, and that they accept full financial and legal responsibility for compliance with all codes and ordinances.

Note: The owner must physically appear and sign — this cannot be mailed in or signed by a representative. A false declaration may constitute perjury, a third-degree felony under FS 775.082, 775.083, and 775.084. The form must be notarized. Note: the owner-builder exemption does NOT apply to in-ground swimming pools (FS 489.103(6)) or to the electrical wiring on solar installations.

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: Building Permit Expiration — New 1-Year Rule for Single-Family Dwellings

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), effective July 1, 2026

State law now sets a 1-year expiration for building permits issued for single-family dwellings, in addition to the department's existing rule that a permit becomes void if work is not commenced within 6 months, or is suspended/abandoned for 1 year after work begins (as printed on the Application for Building Permit form).

Until this is resolved, do not tell applicants the 6-month commencement clock no longer applies — continue quoting both timeframes and let the applicant know both are currently in effect for single-family permits.

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: New Mandatory Permit Review Deadlines

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), amending Florida's permit review deadline framework, effective July 1, 2026

The state now requires local governments to respond to permit applications within set windows once an application is complete: 5 business days for most existing single-family residential permits under \$15,000 (structural, accessory structure, alarm, electrical, gas, irrigation, landscaping, mechanical, plumbing, roofing); 10 business days for CDBG-Disaster Recovery single-family permits; 12 business days for site-specific permits under a master permit; 30 business days for residential projects under 7,500 sq ft; and 60 business days for larger residential, signs, nonresidential under 25,000 sq ft, multifamily (≤ 50 units), and site-plan/plat approvals.

If the county does not issue a timely written notice of any incomplete items within the applicable window, the permit can be deemed approved by law and must be issued the next business day.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Residential Building Permit	\$0.75 / sq ft
Commercial Building Permit	\$0.85 / sq ft
Plumbing, HVAC, Gas & Mechanical	\$150.00 flat
Fire Suppression / Hood / Sprinkler System	\$100.00 each
Pre-Manufactured ADU (Accessory Dwelling Unit)	\$150.00 flat
Factory-Built (Modular) Commercial Building (state insignia; site work only)	\$0.35 / sq ft

Front Desk Tip: What Is an ADU and Who Can Build It?

- **Explanation:** An Accessory Dwelling Unit (ADU) is a secondary, independent living space (like a "mother-in-law suite" or guest house) placed on the same lot as an existing main home.
- **Scenario:** A homeowner wants to place a pre-manufactured tiny home in their backyard for their aging parents.
- **Action:** Charge the \$150.00 ADU flat fee + \$100.00 Tier 1 Site Plan Review to verify setbacks. Even if using the owner-builder exemption to apply, Florida Law (FS 320.8249) mandates a Licensed Mobile Home Installer to perform the actual physical structural setup. Electrical and plumbing hookups must be permitted separately by licensed sub-contractors.

II. Electrical

Use this section for standalone electrical work or trade additions to other permits.

Permit Coverage

Covers: The wiring, panel, and connections for the specific scope listed on the permit (new service, upgrade, outlets/switches, solar, or generator).

Does not cover: The structure the wiring is installed in. A generator installation also requires a separate Gas permit if it is propane- or natural-gas-fed.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Electrical — Residential New Service / Upgrades	\$150.00
Electrical — Commercial New Service / Upgrades	\$200.00
Electrical — Outlets and Switches	\$50.00
Solar / Generator (Panels and Wiring)	\$100.00
Electrical — Residential Interior Wiring (service/meter/panel unchanged)	\$125.00
Electrical — Commercial Interior Wiring (service/meter/panel unchanged)	\$175.00
Electrical — Reconnect / Release (no interior work, no service change)	\$50.00

FORM REQUIRED: Electrical Affidavit

File name: Electrical_Affidavit.pdf

When to use: Required when a property owner is pulling their own electrical permit for power to the site only (e.g., a power pole to a vacant lot, farm, or future build site) — not for connection to any habitable structure. Required before the permit is issued.

What it does: The owner swears under oath that the electrical service is for site power only and will NOT be connected to any residence, mobile home, camper, RV, or other living structure. It acknowledges that a separate permit and inspections are required before any service can connect to a habitable building.

Note: This form does NOT apply when a licensed electrical contractor is pulling the permit. It is owner-specific. If the customer later connects the service to a structure without a permit, they are in violation and the prior affidavit documents their original declaration.

Front Desk Tip: Generator and Solar System Double-Permits

- **Scenario A — Whole-Home Generator:** A customer is installing a backup generator.
- **Action:** This requires two separate trade permits and inspections. They must pull an Electrical permit (\$100) because it hardwires into the main panel, and a Gas permit (\$150) because it hooks up to a propane tank or natural gas line. It must pass an electrical safety inspection and a gas pressure/leak inspection.
- **Scenario B — Solar Panels:** A homeowner wants to install solar panels on their roof using the owner-builder exemption.
- **Action:** Assess the \$100.00 Solar permit fee. Florida Statute explicitly states that a licensed electrical contractor MUST perform all wiring and interconnection to the main panel. They cannot do the wiring themselves.

III. Renovations

Use this section for standalone trades or improvements on existing structures.

Permit Coverage

Covers: The specific trade work listed — plumbing, gas, mechanical, or windows & siding.

Does not cover: Structural changes needed to accommodate the trade work (e.g., removing or altering load-bearing walls) — that requires a separate building permit in addition to the trade permit.

Intake Rules & Verifications

- **The \$7,500 Residential Exemption (HB 803 — Effective July 1, 2026):** Work on a single-family home valued under \$7,500 does not require a building permit if it is strictly cosmetic/non-structural (flooring, cabinets, painting, drywall finishing). A "Written Request for Exemption" must be submitted before work begins.
- **Disqualifiers:** Any electrical, plumbing, mechanical, gas, or structural work **always requires a permit, even if it costs only \$500**. Furthermore, this exemption is completely void if the property sits in a designated flood hazard area. Project splitting to bypass this rule is strictly illegal.
- **Temporary Hurricane / Flood Walls (HB 803 — Effective July 1, 2026):** A second, separate exemption. Installation of a temporary residential hurricane or flood wall that meets specified standards is exempt from permitting entirely — this exemption has no dollar threshold and is distinct from the \$7,500 cosmetic-work exemption above.
- **Bedroom Additions:** If a residential renovation adds a bedroom to a home on a septic tank, a DEP permit is required due to increased system load.

FORM REQUIRED: General Affidavit

File name: General_Affidavit.pdf

When to use: A flexible, multipurpose notarized affidavit used whenever a property owner or applicant needs to make a sworn written statement not covered by a specialized form. Common uses include: documenting special circumstances for a project, attesting to exemption eligibility (such as the HB 803 cosmetic work exemption), or certifying that prior work was completed lawfully.

What it does: The affiant swears before a Notary Public that the facts they are declaring are true and correct to the best of their personal knowledge. The form captures the state, county, affiant name, residency, date, signature, and notary seal.

Note: This is a blank form — staff must inform the applicant what they are attesting to before they sign. Do not let applicants fill it out without understanding its legal purpose. A false statement on this form is a sworn false declaration.

FORM REQUIRED: Owner-Builder Affidavit

File name: Owner_-_Builder_Affidavit.pdf

When to use: Also required here when a property owner is acting as their own general contractor on renovation work — plumbing, mechanical, gas, window replacement, or structural improvements. Same requirement as new construction: the owner must appear in person and sign before the permit is issued. See Section I for full details on this form.

What it does: A 12-point disclosure statement covering the owner's legal obligations, personal liability, supervision responsibilities, and the prohibition on selling or leasing the property within 1 year of completion.

Note: The same restrictions apply as in new construction: must be signed in person, must be notarized, and a false declaration is a third-degree felony. Does not apply to in-ground pools or solar wiring.

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: Temporary Hurricane/Flood Wall Standards — Awaiting Reference Spec

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), effective July 1, 2026

The exemption for temporary residential hurricane and flood walls applies only when the wall meets "specified standards" under the bill.

Do not waive a permit for a hurricane/flood wall until the county has confirmed which standard applies and how staff should verify compliance at intake.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Plumbing, Gas & Mechanical — Residential	\$150.00
Plumbing, Gas & Mechanical — Commercial	\$200.00
Windows & Siding	\$50.00 flat

IV. Mobile homes

Use this section for single mobile home placements and new mobile home parks.

Permit Coverage

Covers: The blocking, anchoring, and tie-down inspection only.

Does not cover: The electrical hookup from the power pole to the home — that requires a separate Residential Electrical permit (Section II) — and plumbing/septic connection, which is handled through DEP.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Mobile Home Set-Up Permit — All Sizes	\$300.00 flat
Mobile Home Park — Development Plan Review	\$1,000.00 or \$25.00 per space, whichever is greater (LDC 4.6-1)

FORM REQUIRED: Mobile Home Permit Worksheet (Blocking Plans)

File name: Blocking_Plans.pdf

When to use: Required for every mobile home set-up permit — new and used homes. The installer must complete this 2-page worksheet before work begins. It must be submitted with or immediately after the permit application.

What it does: Page 1 documents the pier spacing layout, footer sizes, pier pad sizes, marriage wall openings, and tiedown components (LSD manufacturer, lateral arm systems). The installer sketches the actual blocking plan on the grid. Page 2 documents the pocket penetrometer and torque probe soil test results, site preparation, multi-wide fastening details, gasket installation, weatherproofing, plumbing, electrical crossovers, and miscellaneous items. The installer signs and dates Page 2 certifying all information is accurate per Rule 15C-1 and 15C-2.

Note: All tests on Page 2 must be performed by a Licensed Mobile Home Installer — not the property owner. If the home is a single-wide, only half the blocking plan grid needs to be filled out. Triple/quad-wide homes require a full sketch in the remainder section.

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: Manufactured Housing Cannot Be Zoned Differently Than Site-Built Homes

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), effective July 1, 2026

The state now prohibits DBPR from denying a building permit for certain residential manufactured buildings, and restricts local governments from adopting or enforcing zoning, land use, or development regulations that treat offsite-constructed (manufactured) housing differently than site-built housing. The bill also adds specific permit requirements for placement of manufactured housing on mobile home lots and in single-family zoning districts.

In practical terms: staff should not deny or add extra conditions to a mobile home placement in a single-family zoning district solely because the home is manufactured rather than site-built, if it otherwise meets the same standards a site-built home would.

Front Desk Tip: The Mobile Home "Hidden" Costs

- **Scenario:** A customer walks in to pull a permit to move a used double-wide onto their property.
- **Action:** Charge the \$300.00 Set-Up Permit + \$100.00 Tier 1 Site Plan Review.
- **What to tell the customer:** The \$300 setup fee only covers the block, anchor, and tie-down inspection. It does not include electricity or plumbing. They (or their licensed trades) must pull a separate Residential Electrical permit (\$150.00) to hook up the power pole to the home. They must also submit their DEP septic approval before we let them fill out the application.

V. Roofing permit

Use this section for re-roofing and roof repairs on an existing structure. Does not apply to roofing installed as part of new construction — see Section I.

Permit Coverage

Covers: Re-roofing and roof repair on an existing structure, priced by square footage as shown below.

Does not cover: Roofing installed as part of NEW CONSTRUCTION — that's included in the New Construction permit (Section I). Do not charge a separate Roofing Permit fee for a roof going onto a brand-new building.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Roofing Permit — 1 to 1,000 sq ft	\$50.00
Roofing Permit — 1,000 sq ft and above	\$100.00

FORM REQUIRED: Roof Inspection Affidavit (3rd Party)

File name: Roof_Inspection__3rd_Party__Affidavit.pdf

When to use: Required when a roofing permit uses a third-party inspector instead of the county building inspector to verify roof deck nailing and/or secondary water barrier installation. The Third-Party Inspection Discount on the permit fee applies only when this affidavit is submitted. The affidavit is submitted after the inspection is performed.

What it does: The licensed inspector (Engineer, Architect, or FS 468 Building Inspector) certifies under oath that they personally inspected the Roof Deck Nailing and/or Secondary Water Barrier at the job site address, and that the installation meets the Hurricane Mitigation Retrofit Manual per Section 553.844, Florida Statutes. The form must be notarized.

Note: Photographs are required of each plane of the roof, with the permit number or property address clearly visible on the roof deck. Acceptable inspectors include: General, Building, Residential, or Roofing Contractors, or any individual certified under Chapter 468, F.S. General Contractors certified after 1973 without a roofing license cannot perform or certify this inspection.

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: Private Provider (Third-Party Inspector) Rules Substantially Changed

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), amending Fla. Stat. §553.791, effective July 1, 2026

An owner or contractor may now choose to use a private provider at any time, without the prior conditions that used to apply, and no longer has to give the county advance notice of an inspection's date and time. The county's ability to re-review or re-inspect work a private provider has already certified is now much narrower — staff may generally only review private-provider paperwork for completeness, not for substantive code compliance, except for local ordinance, floodplain, and site-review matters.

For the Roof Inspection Affidavit specifically: once a licensed private provider has certified the roof inspection, the county building official may only re-inspect if there is specific knowledge the required inspection was not actually performed, and must give the provider written notice of that concern first.

Front Desk Tip: Contractor Roofing Restrictions

- **Scenario:** A Licensed General Contractor (GC) comes in to pull a roofing permit for a client's standard home overlay.
- **Action:** Check their DBPR license date. Under Florida Law (FS 489.113), GCs certified after 1973 are legally prohibited from pulling standalone roofing permits or self-performing roofing work unless they also hold a dedicated Roofing Contractor license. If they are a post-1973 GC without a roofing license, deny the intake and tell them a licensed roofing contractor must pull it.

VI. Accessory buildings (non-residential)

Use this section for sheds, detached garages, and barns.

Permit Coverage

Covers: The structure itself.

Does not cover: Any plumbing installed inside (sink, toilet, water connection) — that requires a DEP septic permit (see the Pole Barn / Accessory Structure Affidavit). Any electrical requires a separate Electrical permit (Section II).

Intake Rules & Verifications

- **The 120 sq ft Exemption:** Accessory structures and small sheds for single-family or two-family dwellings are explicitly exempt from formal Site Plan Review if they do not constitute major development. Structures under 120 sq ft do not require a structural permit or fee.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Accessory Building — Open (roof only, no walls) — formerly Pole Barn	\$125.00
Accessory Building — Enclosed (any walls) — formerly Pole Barn	\$150.00
Accessory Building — Enclosing an existing permitted open structure	\$50.00
Portable Sheds & Garages — 120 to 400 sq ft	\$30.00
Portable Sheds & Garages — Over 400 sq ft	\$50.00

FORM REQUIRED: Pole Barn / Accessory Structure Affidavit (No Wastewater)

File name: Pole_Barn_Affidavit.pdf

When to use: Required when a property owner is building any accessory structure (shed, barn, garage) and declares that NO plumbing will be installed. Must be signed and notarized before the permit is issued.

What it does: The property owner swears before a Notary Public that the structure is for storage purposes only, will not be used as living or camping quarters (temporary or permanent), and that no plumbing, toilet, or water connection (other than an outside spigot) will be installed. The affidavit warns that violation gives the County Building Inspector and County Commission the right to direct the power company to disconnect electric service until all county ordinances are complied with.

Note: If the applicant mentions a sink, toilet, or any water connection inside the structure, do NOT have them sign this affidavit — they must instead obtain a septic permit from DEP first. This form protects the department if unpermitted plumbing is added later.

Front Desk Tip: Barns, Sheds, and Septic Requirements

- **Scenario:** A resident wants to build an enclosed pole barn to store farm equipment, but mentions they might put a utility sink and a toilet inside for convenience.
- **Action:** Charge the \$150.00 Accessory Building — Enclosed fee. If the applicant confirms no plumbing, have them sign the Pole Barn Affidavit. If they mention any water fixtures, stop — they must submit a DEP septic permit before we proceed. This distinction determines which path the application takes.

VII. Comprehensive plan review

Use this section for zoning approvals, land division, and environmental checks. These fees must be collected upfront.

Permit Coverage

Covers: Approval of the land use and site layout itself (setbacks, parking, drainage, etc.).

Does not cover: A building permit. Site Plan Review and other Comprehensive Plan Review approvals do not substitute for the building permit required before construction begins.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Tier 1 Application Review (Site Plan Approval)	\$100.00
Tier 2 Application Review (Site Plan Approval)	\$350.00
Property Split Review	\$150.00
Comprehensive Plan Amendment — Small-Scale (under 10 acres)	\$1,500.00
Comprehensive Plan Amendment — Large-Scale (over 10 acres)	\$5,000.00
Amendment to Land Development Regulations	\$1,500.00
Application for Subdivision Plat Approval	\$1,000.00 or \$25.00 per lot, whichever is greater (LDC)
Application for Special Exception	\$1,000.00
Variance	\$350.00
Other Conditional Uses	\$2,000.00
Special Temporary Use Permit — Commission Issued	\$200.00
Special Temporary Use Permit — Staff Issued	\$50.00

FORM REQUIRED: Liberty County 911 Address Request

File name: 911_Address_Request.pdf

When to use: Required whenever a new 911 address is needed, an existing address needs to be confirmed, or a current address needs to be corrected. Common triggers: new construction on a vacant lot, placement of a mobile home, installation of a power pole for a future build, or construction of an accessory structure requiring emergency access identification. Collect this form before or alongside the building permit application for any new build or new site.

What it does: The form captures the owner/applicant name, phone, email, parcel ID number, property location/directions, type of request (new address, confirmation, or correction), and purpose of the address (residential dwelling, power pole/utility only, accessory structure, or other). The applicant certifies and signs.

Note: A 911 address must be confirmed or assigned before any inspection can be scheduled on a new structure. Do not issue a Certificate of Occupancy without a confirmed 911 address on file.

Front Desk Tip: Flagging Zoning & Environmental Violations Immediately

- **Scenario A — The 1,000-Foot Alcohol Rule:** An applicant wants to open a small boutique craft beer package store in a commercial zone next to a residential neighborhood.
- **Action:** Inform them this is a Conditional Use / Special Exception (\$1,000.00 fee) that must go before the Board of Adjustment. Instantly check the GIS map. If the property line of the proposed shop is within 1,000 feet of a school, church, public playground, or residential district, tell them it faces an automatic statutory denial under local code.
- **Scenario B — River Buffers & Small Sheds:** A customer wants to put a tiny, 100 sq ft pre-poured plastic shed right on the riverbank of the Apalachicola River. They claim that since it's under 120 sq ft, they don't need the county's permission.
- **Action:** Stop them. Local environmental laws strictly mandate a 75-foot native vegetation buffer from the ordinary high-water line of the Apalachicola River, Ochlockonee River, Telogia Creek, and New River. No structures (except boardwalks/piers) are allowed inside this zone. They must pay a \$100.00 Tier 1 Site Plan Review so planning staff can verify the site clears the 75-foot protected zone.

VIII. Miscellaneous

Use this section for signs, pools, decks, retaining walls, and communication towers.

Permit Coverage

Covers: Swimming Pool permit: the pool structure and required safety barrier. Decks and Ramps permit: the structure itself.

Does not cover: Electrical bonding/wiring for a pool — that requires a separate Electrical permit, and only a licensed contractor may perform that work (FS 489.103(6) excludes pools from the owner-builder exemption). Any electrical for a deck (outdoor lighting, outlets) also requires its own Electrical permit.

Fee Assessment

Permit / Service	Fee
Decks and Ramps — uncovered	\$100.00
Porch, Covered Patio or Attached Carport (roofed, open sides)	\$125.00
Screening an Existing Covered Porch	\$50.00

Permit / Service	Fee
Sign Permit	\$100.00
Swimming Pool — All Sizes	\$100.00
Communication Tower (Conditional Land Use)	\$3,500.00 non-refundable + \$3,000.00 refundable consultant escrow. A performance bond of at least \$75,000 is also required (LDC 8.5-8.7).
Conditional Land Use — Co-Location on Existing Tower	\$2,000.00 non-refundable (LDC 8.6)

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: Retaining Walls Spanning Multiple Parcels — One Permit for the Whole Project

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), effective July 1, 2026

When a retaining wall spans more than one lot or parcel, state law now requires a single building permit covering the project as a whole, rather than a separate permit per parcel.

If a retaining wall project crosses parcel lines, treat it as one permit application listing all affected parcels — do not split it into multiple permits by lot.

Front Desk Tip: Swimming Pool Exemption Trap

- **Scenario:** A homeowner wants to pull an Owner-Builder permit to dig and install their own concrete in-ground swimming pool.
- **Action:** Assess the \$100.00 Swimming Pool permit fee. Politely inform the client that Florida Statute 489.103(6) explicitly excludes in-ground swimming pools from the Owner-Builder exemption. A Licensed Commercial Pool/Spa Contractor (CPC) is legally required to pull the permit and do the work.

IX. Additional permit rules

Use this section for overarching administrative rules, penalties, and discounts that modify the entire application.

Fee Modifiers

Permit / Service	Fee
Third-Party Inspection Discount	40% off permit fee
Plan Review	Included in the permit fee — no separate charge
Penalty — Work started before permit issued	Double the permit fee
Private Provider (s. 553.791, F.S.) — plan review OR inspection: min 25% off; both: min 50% off	Statutory minimum
Permit Expiration — building permit expires 1 year from issuance	No fee
Permit Extension — granted on written request to the Building Department	No fee
Permit Renewal	No renewal fee

Permit / Service	Fee
Additional Inspection — beyond those included with the permit	\$50.00
Re-Inspection — each after the first (first re-inspection free)	\$50.00

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: Mandatory Commercial Fee Reductions When a Private Provider Is Used

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), amending Fla. Stat. §553.791, effective July 1, 2026

State law now sets statutory minimum commercial permit fee reductions when a private provider performs plan review or inspection services: at least 25% off the applicable portion when a private provider performs either plan review or inspection, and at least 50% off when a private provider performs both. If the county fails to apply at least the required reduction, it forfeits its ability to collect any fee for that project.

The department's current Third-Party Inspection Discount is a flat 40%. It has not yet been confirmed whether this rate was designed to apply to commercial private-provider projects, residential ones, or both — the flat rate does not currently distinguish between plan-review-only, inspection-only, and both-services scenarios the way the statute now requires.

2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE: Inspection Fees May No Longer Be Based on Project Valuation

Source: CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), effective July 1, 2026

State law now restricts how inspection fees may be calculated: they can no longer be based on the overall value of a construction project, and must instead reflect the actual cost of providing inspection services, capped at the local government's actual costs incurred.

The department's Residential (\$0.75/sq ft) and Commercial (\$0.85/sq ft) Building Permit fees use square footage as a rough proxy for project value. Whether any portion of these fees is legally an "inspection fee" subject to this restriction, versus a blended permit fee that is not, is a fee-methodology question — not something to resolve at the counter.

Structure Fee Rules — Modification & Structure Type Change (2026 Procedure Update)

New internal guidance for pricing a fee when a previously permitted structure changes, rather than being built new. Two separate rules apply, depending on whether the resulting structure stays in the same fee-schedule category or moves into a different one.

Rule 1 — Same-Category Modification (50%)

The Rule

When a structure has a permit on file that reached final inspection and closed out — even years ago — and it is now being modified into a HIGHER tier within the same fee-schedule category, charge 50% of the fee that would apply if the resulting structure were being permitted for the first time. Expansions that stay within the same size tier carry no fee (see below).

- **Confirm there's a finalized permit on file for the existing structure** — doesn't need to be recent or open, just finalized at some point. No finalized permit = this rate doesn't apply; treat as unpermitted work instead.
- **Identify what the resulting structure would cost as a brand-new build, then charge 50% of that rate** — not 50% of the difference between old and new.

Same-tier expansions are free. If a permitted structure is expanded but stays within the same size tier (e.g., a 200 sq ft shed enlarged to 400 sq ft, both in the same tier), there is no fee — the expansion is not charged. The 50% modification fee applies only when the change moves the structure into a higher tier.

Situation	New-Build Rate	Modification Fee (50%)
Roofing addition pushes home over 1,000 sq ft	\$100.00	\$50.00

Rule 2 — Structure Type Change (Different Category)

The Rule

When a structure moves into a different major fee-schedule category entirely - not just a different tier of the same category, e.g. an accessory structure converted to residential or commercial use - charge the full permit fee for the new category. No credit is given for what was paid on the original permit.

Zoning Comes First — Always

This fee calculation is irrelevant if the new use isn't allowed on that property in the first place. An accessory structure becoming a dwelling or a commercial space is a change of use, which may require Site Plan Review, a Comprehensive Plan check, or a Conditional Use hearing before the Board — all of that has to clear before this fee applies to anything. Never quote a Rule 2 fee before zoning has confirmed the new use is permitted at that location.

Situation	Fee Charged
800 sq ft barn → residential (\$0.75/sq ft)	\$600.00
2,000 sq ft barn → residential (\$0.75/sq ft)	\$1,500.00
Barn → small retail store (800 sq ft, \$0.85/sq ft commercial)	\$680.00

Note: the original permit covered the original structure. A change of use is reviewed and inspected as a new structure of the new type, so it pays that type's full fee.

What Counts as an Accessory Building

"Accessory Building" covers any non-dwelling accessory structure regardless of construction method — pole barns, post-frame, metal or steel-frame barns, aluminum buildings, equipment sheds, carports, shops, workshops, lean-tos, and similar. The fee is set by whether the structure is open or enclosed (Open \$125 / Enclosed \$150), not by what it is built from. Note: a structure that will be lived in is NOT an accessory building — a pole barn house or barndominium is permitted as new residential construction at the residential per-square-foot rate.

X. Glossary of common terms & required documents

Refer to this glossary when explaining building and zoning requirements to the public.

1. Required Legal & Agency Documents

Application for Building Permit: The primary intake form required for every permit type. Captures property, owner, contractor, project description, valuation, zoning, and utility information. Issued by the Liberty County Building Department; assigns the Permit #, Fee, and surcharges. Expected to be replaced by a standardized statewide form no later than July 1, 2027, per HB 803.

Notice of Commencement (NOC): A legal document required by the state for any construction project where the job value exceeds \$2,500 (or \$15,000 for HVAC changeouts). It must be recorded with the Clerk of Court and filed with the building department before the first inspection can be scheduled.

Owner-Builder Affidavit: A 12-point statutory disclosure statement (FS 489.103(7)) signed in person by a property owner acting as their own general contractor. Acknowledges legal restrictions, personal liability, and the prohibition on selling or leasing the property within one year of completion.

Electrical Affidavit: Signed by a property owner pulling their own electrical permit for site power only. Certifies the service will not connect to any habitable structure and that a separate permit is required for any such connection.

Pole Barn / Accessory Structure Affidavit: Signed by a property owner building a non-residential accessory structure with no plumbing. Certifies the structure will not be used for living or camping and contains no water connections. Violation authorizes the county to direct disconnection of electric service.

Roof Inspection Affidavit (3rd Party): Signed by a licensed third-party inspector (Engineer, Architect, or FS 468 Inspector) certifying that the roof deck nailing and/or secondary water barrier was installed per Section 553.844, F.S. Required to apply the Third-Party Inspection Discount on roofing permit fees. Subject to the narrowed local re-review standard under HB 803.

General Affidavit: A blank, multipurpose notarized affidavit for sworn statements not covered by specialized forms. Used for exemption declarations, attestations of prior lawful work, or other written certifications. Staff must inform the affiant what they are swearing to before signing.

Mobile Home Permit Worksheet (Blocking Plans): A 2-page form completed by the licensed mobile home installer documenting pier spacing, pad sizes, soil test results, tiedown components, site preparation, plumbing, electrical crossovers, and weatherproofing. Required for every mobile home set-up permit.

911 Address Request: A Liberty County form used to request a new 911 address, confirm an existing address, or correct an address on record. Required at intake for any new construction, mobile home placement, or power pole installation on a vacant parcel.

Written Request for Exemption (HB 803): A document required from a homeowner or contractor stating their single-family residential project is non-structural, non-trade, outside a flood zone, and valued under \$7,500, exempting them from a standard building permit. A separate, no-threshold exemption also applies to qualifying temporary hurricane/flood walls.

Septic Permit / Existing System Approval: An official clearance issued by the Florida Department of Environmental Protection (DEP). Required before the county can intake building permits for any new build, mobile home setup, or home renovation that adds a bedroom on a lot utilizing a septic tank.

Private Provider: A licensed engineer, architect, or building code administrator authorized under Fla. Stat. §553.791 to perform plan review or inspection services in place of the local building department. HB 803 (2026) expanded when and how private providers can be used and narrowed the county's authority to re-review their work.

2. Property & Use Types

Commercial Use: Any land use involving trade or retail with the general public, as opposed to manufacturing or wholesale distribution.

Single-Family Dwelling (Residential): A private residential building intended for one family unit, containing one kitchen and exactly one electrical meter.

Multifamily Dwelling (Residential): A residential building designed for or occupied exclusively by three (3) or more separate families. (Note: A duplex is considered a two-family dwelling, not multifamily.)

Accessory Building / Use: A subordinate building or use (like a detached garage, carport, or tool shed) that is located on the same lot as the main principal building.

Mobile Home: A dwelling unit constructed entirely off-site and transported to the property. It must meet strict HUD or ANSI construction standards based on its manufacture date. Local zoning may not treat it differently than site-built housing under HB 803 (2026).

Recreational Vehicle (RV): A vehicle built on a single chassis, 400 square feet or less, designed strictly as temporary living quarters for camping, travel, or seasonal use — never to be used or permitted as a permanent dwelling.

3. Zoning & Administrative Terms

Setback: The minimum required horizontal distance that structures must be kept back from property lines or right-of-ways. No buildings can encroach into this space.

Lot Coverage: The total percentage of a land parcel that is physically covered by roofs, buildings, or overhanging structures.

Site Plan Review: The administrative review process where staff checks a development's layout (parking, drainage, setbacks, and buffers) against local regulations before a building permit is granted.

Variance: A special grant of dimensional relief from zoning codes (such as built setbacks). It is only granted by the Board of Adjustment when a physical hardship unique to the land makes it impossible to follow literal code.

Conditional Use / Special Exception: A land use that is not permitted "by right" in a zoning district due to its high-impact nature (like an alcohol establishment or tower). It requires a public hearing and specific site conditions approved by the Board to ensure neighborhood compatibility.

XI. Quick reference: form lookup by situation

Use this table when a customer is at the counter and you need to quickly identify which forms apply to their project.

Customer Situation	Forms Required
Any permit (every project)	Application for Building Permit
Job value over \$2,500	Notice of Commencement (before 1st inspection)
New construction or mobile home — no city sewer	Septic Permit from DEP (before intake)
No confirmed 911 address on file	911 Address Request
Owner acting as own contractor (any project)	Owner-Builder Affidavit (signed in person)
Property owner pulling site electrical only	Electrical Affidavit
Mobile home placement (new or used)	Mobile Home Permit Worksheet (Blocking Plans)
Roofing permit with third-party inspector (discount)	Roof Inspection Affidavit (3rd Party)
Barn, shed, garage — no plumbing planned	Pole Barn / Accessory Structure Affidavit
Sworn statement needed, no specialized form applies	General Affidavit
HB 803 cosmetic work exemption claim (under \$7,500)	Written Request for Exemption (General Affidavit may supplement)
Temporary hurricane/flood wall (HB 803)	Written Request for Exemption — pending standard confirmation

XII. 2026 legislative update summary

Every 2026 LEGISLATIVE UPDATE box in this guide traces back to CS/CS/HB 803 (2026), Chapter 2026-63, Laws of Florida, effective July 1, 2026. This table lists them all in one place.

Change	Status
\$7,500 nonstructural exemption	Ready to use
Temporary hurricane/flood wall exemption	Pending standard confirmation

Change	Status
1-year single-family permit expiration	Pending interaction with 6-month rule
New 5/10/12/30/60-day review deadlines	Pending tracking workflow
Manufactured housing zoning nondiscrimination	Pending zoning code review
Retaining wall — one permit per multi-parcel project	Ready to use
HOA cannot require permit before architectural review	Ready to use (informational)
Narrowed local re-review of private providers	Pending internal policy update
Mandatory 25%/50% commercial fee reduction for private providers	Pending fee-schedule review
Inspection fees restricted from value-based calculation	Pending fee-schedule review
Statewide uniform permit application (due July 2027)	Future — no action yet